

PRESENTING YOUR CASE



Sometimes, too much can also mean too problematic. With the number of features that presentation software have these days, it's a problem selecting the right presentation for your needs.

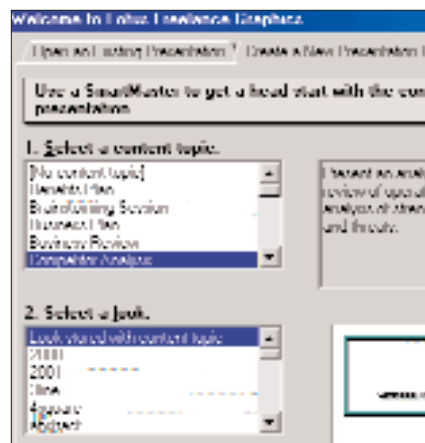
Wizard and templates

All the presentation packages allow you to start off with a wizard where you can specify the layouts and themes. With StarOffice Impress, the wizard takes you through the whole gamut of operations—select templates, specify page type, the output medium, indicate the transition—and your slide is ready. We didn't particularly like the templates that much—the colour schemes seemed a bit too garish. An interesting feature with Lotus is that you even have templates for the content of the slides. Select one and Freelance Graphics auto-generates content for multiple slides (or pages) based on the options related to the template. For instance, if you choose Competitor Analysis as the content topic, then you have options for pages with content such as Background, Human Resource Strategy, Anticipated Moves, etc.

Formatting

What we tried to do was select a template and then try customising the template to our needs. In StarOffice Impress, if you have to change the background objects,

you need to enter the Background view (located at the bottom pane of the screen and easy to miss) and enter the Drawing mode. In Freelance Graphics, the same thing is made quite simple by using the Edit > Backdrop option. With PowerPoint 2002, you don't have too much of that problem either, clicking on an object allows you to select it.



Working with content templates in Lotus

An interesting feature Impress sports is the Bezier tool, which is normally only present in graphics packages. This can be quite useful for creating curved paths with text flowing around it. Freelance Graphics also presents you with a number of graphical

tools to add different connectors, flow charts, points, arrows, and even create irregular shapes with text within the shapes.

Slide Show

All the presentation software had easy-to-use slide show options, with the facility to add notes or to use a pen. Apart from a slide show, you could even have output in the form of handouts if you desire. Impress even allows you to edit while the presentation was on. PowerPoint has a live broadcast feature, though we didn't actually check out how this feature works.

Freelance Graphics treats each line, image or clipart as a separate object. Therefore, you can modify the properties for each object (say a bulleted text) and this greatly helps in sequencing (selecting which object will be displayed first) during a presentation. For instance, just right-click on a particular object (say a bulleted list), select the properties for that object, and specify whether you want the object displayed with the page or after a mouse-click or after a certain time duration. Add other aspects such as the transition effect you want when the image appears or even add the action that has to be performed when the object is clicked on (for instance, you can specify that a movie be played, or the next slide be presented, etc). Not just that, you even have content advice related to the content template that you have created. If this isn't spoon-feeding, what is?

PowerPoint 2002 leaves the rest far behind when it comes to the task of creating slide shows and adding custom animation. Just right-click on any object (text, image, etc) and you get all the options you could ever want. You can specify animation characteristics, effects, sequence the objects on the page, and all with Auto Preview (if you have the option checked). The number of animation effects, templates, slide designs and layouts have all increased considerably. Also, with the same right-click option you can specify a certain action for the object, if clicked or on a mouseover. The action you define can, for instance, be playing a sound or running a program.

In terms of sheer features, there's nothing that can beat **PowerPoint 2002**. Freelance Graphics, like WordPro and 1-2-3, offers more simplicity and optimal utilisation of workspace, so if you like your presentations simple, then definitely check these out.

Pack and Go

Alright! You've just created the best sales report ever with high-quality images and graphs. But how do you send this huge file over to your branch manager based in a different location, and also ensure that there are no problems with the fonts and image display? That's why all presentation suites come with a 'packing the presentation' option.

Impress allows you to split your file into different file sizes (based on the output medium). So, you can split the file into 1.44-MB sizes if you are transferring it via floppy. Impress also comes with an option to keep placeholders instead of the actual image or text. This can be useful in a collaborative work environment where you are initially discussing the layout of the presentation without using the actual content or images.

PowerPoint 2002 comes with a number of options for packing your presentations. For images, you can specify compression ratios and resolution and also choose whether to embed the fonts into the file (so as to not cause a font mismatch if the person viewing the file doesn't have these fonts installed on his system).

Also, you can just use the Send To option to send the file as an attachment to an e-mail recipient. Freelance Graphics's Save and Go feature allows you to compress the file and save it in different output mediums, and it also allows you to insert images as a link (that means the actual image isn't there, it's just a placeholder) instead of embedding the image. This is again useful for reducing the file size.